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Modes of persuasion

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Throughout these disputes the role of verbal skill appears to cross-cut sacred and secular powers. However, on closer inspection, different types of speech tend to dominate different conflict situations and provoke and persuade in contrasting ways, depending on the kinds of powers and social persons they are associated with. These constitute rhetorical differences between individuals in different power positions based upon different sources of status, wealth, and personal circumstances, rather than the nature of the dispute. Tuareg believe that speech uttered by certain people, in specific kinds of statuses and relationships, influences events. There are different varieties of speech and conversation, each denoted by a distinct term in Tamacheq, surrounded by beliefs about its impact on sacred and secular events, and associated with different social statuses and roles. This illuminates the ritual and jural significance of covert speech in conflict mediation. For example, *awal* or gossip is considered a vehicle of evil spirits. All Tuareg, except blacksmiths who are free from constraint of reserve and dignity, attempt to measure words, and avoid commenting about everything happening around them. To comment provokes gossip, described as "evil mouth" (*imi wa kawala* or *imi n edduniet*), and persons having this trait are referred to as having "a black tongue." This speech ultimately causes destruction of person and property, a significant threat in relationships featuring cooperative work and intermarriage. Ramatou feared her property attracted a "bad fate" from gossip and eventually moved. The power of speech may render bad what is good, and may take the form of *tehot*, admiring possessions or being jealous of them and expressing this in conversation. This speech may infect the owner and their place of residence. Other types of speech are specific to certain groups and situations; *Tenet*, described by residents as "twisted Tamacheq," and believed to be close to the language of the spirits, is spoken by blacksmiths who wish confidentiality; and *Tagenagen*, is spoken by persons of slave origin. The latter is sometimes spoken jokingly, for instance at a wedding

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celebration. The groom asked his sister where the bride was in Tagenagen because he did not wish to be understood by everyone present; the spectators included many future affines, toward whom he would soon practice extreme respect, but with whom he now could joke. *Eljimat* refers to courtship conversation between men and women; I frequently heard Tuareg women judge a man's worthiness as a suitor by discussing his "manner of talking" and his voice quality.

These different types of speech used to invoke power further illuminate the meaning of covert speech in the exorcism ritual, in divination, and in gossip and peer pressure used to exert influence at different points in conflicts. Speech forms are linked to a number of powers in Tuareg society and cosmology, some of whom are friendly and dependable "allies" of the plaintiff in a dispute, and some of whom are unfriendly and unreliable. Thus indirect expression and divergent channels of communication become important in the resolution of conflict for different persons, depending upon who they are and which authority they challenge in their dispute. For example, it is said that possessing *goumaten* spirits prefer beautiful songs and are placated by them. These spirits are inherited from mother to daughter, and often walk about on Moslem holidays. In Tuareg culture song is opposed to prayer and many marabouts forbid the enactment of exorcism rites and musical festivals near mosques and on Moslem prayer-days. Marabouts and the Sultan of Agadez possess *al baraka*, or life blessing power, and invoke this by pronouncing a blessing in conflict situations where greater openness is allowed, due to more "buffers" between the parties. Marabouts' blessings are effective in situations of social convention, where there is little ambiguity. Cases of ambiguity are more problematic, but also less constraining, for the parties.

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In some situations protests will convince; in others, they will only bring reprisals. For example, women dread disapproval of parents and marabouts because they control access to material property. On the other hand, men dread women's ridicule because they hold power over men's personal esteem in public reputation as proclaimed in poetry and song, as well as the power to throw them out of the domestic tent. Men I knew who experienced these measures felt, in effect, not only denied a place of residence, but also stripped of their sense of personal identity, both in terms of gender role and class prerogative. Dignity, reserve, and generosity may be at specific times difficult to maintain, but over the long term these comprise the basis of self-concepts as well as the prerequisite to future material security. For individuals of either sex and all 44 social segments, affines (particularly parents-in-law) hold the "cards" in everyday life and control success in subsistence and transition to jural adulthood. Cousins and neighbors depend upon each other for mutual aid and support. Chiefs' leverage is based upon their key role in tax collection. Nobles or persons of mixed ancestry are vulnerable to gossip about their alleged or actual slave descent, and experience shame when this is invoked, regardless of their socioeconomic position. Everyone feels shame when an internal weakness or discord is exposed to an outsider.

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